STAY SAFE CHECKLIST

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Comprehensive Prevention Checklist: Staying Safe in the Digital Indian Campus

1. Introduction

As college students in India, our lives are increasingly lived through screens. From attending online lectures and filling out scholarship forms to using UPI for a quick cutting chai or hostel canteen meal, our digital footprint is massive. However, with this convenience comes the risk of cyber-attacks, financial fraud, and identity theft. This checklist serves as an actionable guide to safeguarding your digital life.

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2. Financial & UPI Safety (Critical)

Tip 1: The "PIN is for Giving" Rule

One of the most common scams in India involves the misuse of "Collect Requests." Fraudsters often pose as buyers on platforms like OLX or as "Scholarship Officers" on Telegram.

- **The Action:** Never enter your UPI PIN to *receive* money. A PIN is only required when you are authorizing a debit from your account.
- **Campus Scenario:** If someone claims they are sending you a "prize" for a college fest and asks you to "scan a QR and enter your PIN," it is 100% a scam.

Tip 2: Merchant Verification and App Limits

UPI apps like GPay, PhonePe, and Paytm display the legal name of the account holder.

- **The Action:** Before hitting 'Pay' at a local xerox shop or canteen, look at the screen to ensure the name matches the shop. Furthermore, set a **Daily Transaction Limit** on your banking app. If your phone is stolen, this prevents a thief from emptying your account in one go.

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3. Protecting Your Digital Identity

Tip 3: Aadhaar Masking & Photocopy Ethics

College students frequently share Aadhaar copies for SIM cards, hostel registrations, or internship onboarding.

- **The Action:** Avoid sharing your full 12-digit Aadhaar number. Use the **"Masked Aadhaar"** option available on the UIDAI website, which only shows the last four digits ($XXXX-XXXX-1234$).

- **Pro-Tip:** When giving a physical photocopy, write the purpose across the photo (e.g., "For Internship use only - Date") in ink so it cannot be reused for opening fake bank accounts.

Tip 4: Social Media Metadata & Privacy

Posting a "First Day of College" selfie or a "Hostel Life" reel is common, but it can reveal more than you think.

- **The Action:** Turn off "Location Tags" in your camera settings. Digital stalkers can use the EXIF data (metadata) of your photos to find your exact hostel room or the timings of your daily commute. Keep your profiles on 'Private' and audit your follower list once a month.

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4. Connectivity & Device Security

Tip 5: The Perils of Campus Wi-Fi

University Wi-Fi networks are often "open" or use shared passwords, making them vulnerable to "Man-in-the-Middle" (MitM) attacks where a hacker intercepts your data.

- **The Action:** Never access your banking apps or enter passwords for sensitive portals while on public Wi-Fi without a **VPN (Virtual Private Network)**. If you don't have a VPN, use your mobile data for sensitive tasks.

Tip 6: Managing "WhatsApp Group" Links

College WhatsApp groups are flooded with links for "Free PDF Textbooks," "Exam Leak Portals," or "Work from Home Internships."

- **The Action:** Before clicking, hover over the link or use a "Link Expander" tool to see the actual destination. Many of these links lead to **Phishing sites** designed to steal your Instagram or Gmail credentials. If a deal looks too good to be true (e.g., "Earn ₹5000/day by liking YouTube videos"), it is a trap.

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5. Account Hygiene & Recovery

Tip 7: Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA)

Relying solely on a password is no longer enough.

- **The Action:** Enable 2FA on your primary Gmail (linked to your college records) and Instagram. Avoid SMS-based 2FA if possible, as "SIM Swapping" is on the rise in India. Use app-based authenticators like **Google Authenticator** or **Microsoft Authenticator**.

Tip 8: Secure File Sharing

Students often use shared computers in college labs to print assignments.

- **The Action:** Never leave your WhatsApp Web or Gmail logged in on a lab computer. Always use **Incognito Mode** for such tasks. If you use a USB drive, scan it for "Shortcut Viruses" before opening it on your personal laptop, as these are rampant in campus print shops.

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6. Official Reporting Channels

In India, cybercrime is a serious offense, and the government has established dedicated infrastructure to help students and citizens.

The National Cyber Crime Portal

- **URL:** cybercrime.gov.in
- **When to use:** For reporting online harassment, financial fraud, identity theft, or any cyber-related grievance. You can report anonymously if the crime is of a sensitive nature.

The 1930 Helpline

- **Phone Number: 1930**
- **The "Golden Hour":** If you lose money to a digital scam, call 1930 immediately. If reported within the first hour, the authorities have a much higher chance of "freezing" the money in the scammer's account before they can withdraw it.

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7. Prevention Summary Table

Category	Action	Why it Matters
Financial	Never enter PIN to receive money	Prevents "Collect Request" fraud.
Identity	Use Masked Aadhaar	Prevents unauthorized use of your ID.
Network	Use VPN on Campus Wi-Fi	Protects data from being intercepted.
Accounts	Enable 2FA / MFA	Adds a second layer of defense.
Social	Remove Location Metadata	Protects physical safety from stalkers.